Kipworth

Go To Bed. Please.

Three things that actually helped, at bedtime and at 2 am. For knackered parents.

Real words from real parents.
No lectures. One checklist for tonight.

Kipworth

If bedtime is breaking you, read this first

> "Nothing has consistently worked."
>
> **a parent on Mumsnet**

> "We've made a rod for our own back"
>
> **a dad on Reddit**

If that's you, hello. The most upvoted reply under that Dad's post wasn't a tip. It was this:

> "When you're old, you won't look back on this time and wished you'd cuddled her less so please don't feel like you've made a rod for your back."
>
> **a parent on Reddit**

> "It's okay for this to no longer be sustainable for you but it's also okay for your daughter to be upset about the change."
>
> **a parent on Reddit**

Read that second one again. Both halves are true, and they're true tonight.

You're allowed to change this. Not because you got it wrong. Because it doesn't work for you any more.

And they're allowed not to like it. You can be kind, keep every promise to come back, and still have an upset child at lights out. That isn't you getting it wrong. It's what a change sounds like.

Below: three things other parents actually did. Two for bedtime. One for 2 am. Pick the one that sounds like your house.

1. Back in two minutes. Every time. (bedtime)
2. Room time, not sleep time. (bedtime)

3 The 2 am plan (the night)

Tip 1

Back in two minutes. Every time.

> "Next time you're settling her and it's taking a while, I'd simply say you need to go for a wee and will be right back, then do exactly that."
>
> **a parent on Reddit**

Why it goes wrong

What they dread isn't you leaving, it's you not coming back. So you practise the coming back, two minutes at a time, until it's old news.

Tonight

1 Say you need a wee, and go.

Not "I'll be back in a bit", not a negotiation: "Just nipping to the loo. Back in two minutes." Then actually go, whether you need one or not, and count to a hundred on the landing.

2 Come back. Every single time.

The parent who suggested this was clear: "make sure you do always return so that she trusts this." Tonight isn't about getting out of the room. It's about proving the door works both ways.

3 Stretch it, slowly.

Two minutes tonight. Later in the week, the kettle. Next week, a quick job downstairs. The same parent still cuddles most nights and keeps this for "nights that I need to be cracking on with housework or if I'm just feeling a bit touched out". Both can be true. Where it ends up, from a parent on Mumsnet: "What works for us is to say Goodnight, leave but come back at intervals. We started off with leaving for 5 minutes until we come back. These days he's happy with 20 minutes."

The trap

Saying two minutes and taking twenty: one broken promise and the trick is spent. The trust is the trick.

The Dad who asked, back on the thread:

> "Live update: I did the going for a wee thing and she was ok with that. I watched her door for 2 mins. Her light came on for 30 secs, then back off again. I got back in to bed with her. She's just dropped off about 5 mins ago. Now to remove my arm from under her...."
>
> **a dad on Reddit**

Half a win, and he says so himself: he got back into bed with her. The other half is new, though. She let him go.

Tip 2

Room time, not sleep time

> "Take the pressure of a bit and say 8pm is in her room time but let her decide when she wants to sleep and break the habit of sitting with her. So do 1 story then you say goodnight and leave."
>
> **a parent on Mumsnet**

Why it goes wrong

Somewhere along the way, bed turned into a test. Lie still, try to sleep, not yet, try harder. The harder anyone tries to drop off, the further away it gets, and by half nine the whole house knows it. One parent on Mumsnet stopped marking the test, and chose instead to "tell him it doesn't matter if he sleeps or not".

> “This helped tremendously as it took away the pressure of bed = sleep which he felt stressed about when he wasn’t sleeping easily.”
>
> **a parent on Mumsnet**

Bed = sleep. That’s the sum that stops adding up at nine o’clock. Take the sleep out of it, and a bed is just a bed in a room that’s theirs.

Tonight

1. **Say it at tea time, in daylight, in these words.**
   “From eight o’clock it’s room time, not sleep time. You don’t have to sleep. You just have to be in your room. Sleep when you’re ready.” That’s the parent at the top of this page: “8pm is in her room time but let her decide when she wants to sleep”. If it helps, add the line that did the work for the second parent: it doesn’t matter if you sleep or not.

2 One story. Goodnight. Out.

The exact words from the top of this page: "So do 1 story then you say goodnight and leave." Not a second story, not a sit on the end of the bed until they're gone: that sitting is the habit that parent set out to break. If what they need is you back in the room, that's Tip 1, not this one. Say you need a wee, and come back.

3 If sleep won't come, a book can.

No telling off for being awake. From another parent on Mumsnet: "If he can't sleep we let him play or read in his room, he usually settles within 30mins." Read, play quietly, in their room, with the lights how they usually are. Awake in their room counts. Asleep is their business.

The trap

Going back up to check whether they're asleep yet. Or the line through the door, "you should be asleep by now". Either one puts the sleep back on the bed, and the test is back on. Room time is room time. What they do with it, awake or asleep, is theirs.

Two years on, in the same house

> "...we've been doing it for about 2 years with her and it works really well for her. We get an evening, she's not pressured and gets enough sleep!"
>
> **a parent on Mumsnet**

Two years, not two nights. And read the middle bit again: "We get an evening".

Tip 3

The 2 am plan

> "We gave up trying to return him to his own room as it resulted in screaming and even less sleep for us all."
>
> **a parent on Reddit**

Why it goes wrong

At 2 am nobody is at their best, and a rule invented at 2 am is a different rule every night. Giving up the walk back isn't failing: it's noticing what costs the house the most sleep.

Tonight

1 Pick the plan in daylight, and say it at tea time.

Two honest options. One: a camp bed or airbed on your floor, and no climbing into the big bed. Two: back to their own bed, kindly, by whichever of you is less knackered. Either can work as a rule. Neither works as a surprise. From a parent on Mumsnet: "We had lots of conversations about it in the daytime so we were clear about what would happen at night." And what the nights look like now: "She goes to sleep alone in her bed but we never enforced it. So she knows she can come in the night, which she does sometimes but always goes to sleep in her own bed alone now."

2 If it's the airbed, make it theirs.

Their pillow, their teddy, laid out before bed so there's nothing to sort at 2 am. From another parent on Mumsnet: "Just adapting to it (no guilt/drama/bribes) and him knowing the airbed is there if he needs it, has been the best thing we did."

3 If it's their own bed, the silent walk back.

Not a telling off, not a speech: the rule from tea time, kept. Hand on the shoulder, back to the room, "It's bedtime", out, in the same sleepy voice every time. And in the morning, make a fuss about what went right, even if it was one hour out of ten.

The trap

A rule that drifts: the floor bed that quietly turns into "our bed, actually". Say "The airbed, yes. Our bed, no." in daylight, and give the same answer every night.

Tonight's checklist

> "I have tried it all on a consistent basis and nothing works!"
>
> **a parent on Reddit**

Lights down, screens off, the same steps at the same time, one story. Already doing all that? Then it was never the routine. Start with Tip 1.

Tonight: what you did, not what went perfectly

- [ ] "Just nipping to the loo." Back in two minutes, as promised.
- [ ] From 8, room time. A book is fine. Sleep comes when it comes.
- [ ] The 2 am plan said out loud, at tea time.
- [ ] 2 am: the plan, not a new plan.
- [ ] Morning: a fuss about what went right.

Ticked one? That's one more than last night.

Now tell us about your evening

> "I don't need 3 hours of downtime a night but 30 mins would be nice."
>
> **a parent on Reddit**

Hit reply and tell us about tonight. One line each:

1. What time did they actually fall asleep?
2. Which tip did you try, and what happened? ("Nothing" counts.)

We read every reply ourselves. Nothing to buy at the bottom.

Thirty minutes to yourself. Not three hours. Thirty.

Sleep well. Or at least, sleep.

Kipworth